LIVE VISUALS

History, Theory, Practice

Edited by Steve Gibson, Stefan Arisona, Donna Leishman and Atau Tanaka

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INTERVIEW 2: CHRISTOPHER THOMAS ALLEN, FOUNDER AND DIRECTOR, THE LIGHT SURGEONS

Steve Gibson

Introduction

The Light Surgeons have operated for over 20 years as a studio creating a variety of multimedia projects and are one of the international pioneers of live cinema. This interview with founder and director Christopher Thomas Allen covers their recent live cinema work *SuperEverything** as well as their involvement in the development of VJing and the practice of creating Live Visuals for various music acts such as ZERO7, U.N.K.L.E., the Sneaker Pimps and U2 in the 1990s and early 2000s.

STEVE GIBSON (SG): Could you outline what led you to live cinema and how The Light Surgeons have developed your distinct identity over the past two decades?

CHRIS ALLEN (CA): Sure. The Light Surgeons as a collective or a company, began when I was studying Media Design at Portsmouth University. I had started experimenting a little bit with projection before going to study when I was very young, about 18. My brother was a hip-hop, rare groove DJ in London, in the early 90s acid jazz scene. I was very influenced by what was going on with graphic design and what you might term as retro music back then. I was also influenced by what was happening with hip-hop music and sample culture in general. Rather than replicating what my brother was doing with his DJing and music production, I thought it would be interesting to try and find a way of visualising these things by exploring that kind of sampling and cut up culture in a visual way.

My dad was a photographer, so I was brought up around a lot of 35 mm film and slides. He used to produce a lot of his work on slide transparency. I'd also been exposed to cine film from very young age. My mum had

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lost her father when she was quite young. My grandfather was a very early adopter of technology apparently, he built his own television she told me, he was an electrical engineer and he'd been a real film buff when she was a kid. My mum had continued this passion for shooting home movies, and so as we grew up we had a lot of cine films of us that we would project on to the walls at home. My interest in moving image really began with that, just being amazed at how projecting onto things changed their context, and being able to layer and collage other things together with projection was really exciting. It seemed to have a real synergy with the music I was listening to at the time, so when I went to university to study graphic design I was looking for ways I could involve these ideas in my work.

The Light Surgeons really began as a group or collective of artists that I met at university who were all interested in exploring experimental work with projection, mainly myself and an artist called Paul O'Conner. For Paul, me and a few others it was an outlet for us to make a bit of money on the side while studying. We ended up doing visual projections for a few local clubs and music gigs, and that's where it really started as a name and profession.

It didn't really become an actual limited company and studio until I graduated from university. I met another artist called Andy Flywheel who became my business partner. We began doing a lot of shows together, he was already doing these projections with Super-8 film projectors so we teamed up and started to work under The Light Surgeons name. I'd had developed this collection of graphic slides using back and white reversal lithographic film and lighting gels which gave us these very screen-printed graphic elements to composite our Super-8 film projections around (see Figure 17.1). We quickly outgrew Super-8 and started to shoot and process 16mm film so we could get a negative of the work we had done.

All of the early stuff we did was very analogue. We didn't have the money to get our hands on any video stuff. We were both really into this analogue aesthetic, we loved the analogue process and happy accidents it brought into play. I think that's what people were drawn to in our work. We were creating these fuzzy analogue collages using multiple slide projectors (see Figure 17.2). We used a lot of sequences of graphic slides which had a super high contrast. When you projected them, you wouldn't get any anything other than the shapes in the image so they sort of floated in space.

When you're using lots of projectors, you can composite stuff together into these immersive, layered compositions. I guess we were doing a form of analogue compositing without any digital tools or access to video editing software. We achieved these effects on film by masking things off in camera. To begin with, we would take samples from our favourite films from VHS tape back onto 16mm film. This is before we had access to digital cameras and editing kind of facilities like Final Cut. You could only get access to non-linear editing in Soho post houses on AVIDs and that cost way too much money back then.

FIGURE 17.1 The Light Surgeons, *Ninja Tune Idents*, 1996. Video by Chris Allen and Andy Flywheel, Music by Kid Koala and DJ Vadim, www.lightsurgeons.com/com/ninja-tune-idents/ Used by Permission.

Source: Mail conversation with artist available on request.

We invented our own way to sample by basically re-filming little bits from the films that we loved on VHS tape that we had recorded or hired. It was a direct parallel to what people were doing with music. We'd go and take a tiny bit from a science fiction film that had a beautiful graphics sequence, like the titles, or a GUI interface, or a moment that we thought that we could make an interesting loop out of. We'd sample that section of the film by going frame by frame from the VHS tape back onto 16 mm film by setting up a camera and tripod in front of an old TV set. We could tweak the contrast and effectively do a colour grade on it by changing the settings on television. It was a slow and painful process, but we could reanimate the sequences in a very precise way using this technique. We could create perfect loops, layer them, do multiple exposures all from video back onto 16mm film. It was a strange reversal of what most people were doing then but the limitations gave us a lot of creative possibilities.

A lot of our early light shows combined that approach to making film loops with this very strong graphic design aesthetic. With a lot of

FIGURE 17.2 The Light Surgeons, Andy Flywheel and Christopher Thomas Allen in operation at The Blue Note club, Hoxton Square, East London, 1996, Photo by Jamie B. Used by Permission.

Source: Mail conversation with artist available on request.

analogue projectors we were able to cover huge amounts of space, and were able to create these immersive environments that would totally surround people in projections. They became entangled in these images and the projections became architectural, it was really exciting. As things developed and we made some money, we gradually started to introduce elements of video into these shows. We started with VHS tapes and using the Panasonic MX50 vision mixer, and then eventually we managed to scrape enough money together to invest in our own a digital camera with a Firewire connection. When Final Cut Pro came out for the Mac, that really changed it all really. Suddenly we were able to film a lot more of our own stuff and the work took on a more documentary direction. The slides started to become much more focused on my own photography of actual things, the world around us, travel, transportation and architecture. I also got very interested in taking multiple exposures on slide film. I would take a photo and hold it in my memory until I took another. It was a way of compressing time and space for me. It was also a way adding more layers to the projected collage, rather than needing several projectors I could take multiple photographs. We just got really into this idea of multiple layers and collage to form these static visual structures that we could then bring to life with the film loops.

SG: Did you abandon sample appropriation at that point?

CA: It got to a point for me where I felt like there was only so far we could go with sampling. I just got a lot more excited by taking a more documentary approach. I mean, why spend so much time rehashing someone else's work when you can create your own images? I think it's fine if you're doing it to make a comment on something. For me, if you're using someone else's material, then you've got to be saying something with it, there needs to be a conscious statement in the action in my opinion. It's way too easy to just remix or mash stuff together. It can become meaningless. I think I also just became really interested in documenting the world around me, that excited me a lot more and it was what led me to recording audio interviews with people and start making work with a narrative, which ultimately led to us making more short films and work I would describe as live cinema.

SG: This next question will lead on from that, leading into your live cinema work. I know you have an interest in in traditional film, but in your experience, what are the fundamental differences between traditional film and live cinema?

CA: The obvious fundamental difference is that it's presented live and can change or be different each time. There are similarities, but the fundamental differences are that live cinema is something that's evolving. There's a finality to film, you make a final cut, you go through a process and arrive at a final point, and there's something quite nice about that in a way. Part of what frustrated me about the creative practice of VJing in the early days of doing shows was that it became this endless remix. You could always re-appropriate the footage, change it a little bit, rehash it, mix it with something else and there was no end point. A frustration with that and a lack of critical feedback is what actually drove me towards making more linear, narrative-driven film work. This frustration resulted in a series of short experimental documentary films that were commissioned by onedotzero festival.[1] (see Figure 17.3)

After making these shorts, when we went back to making our own live shows. I think we were looking to introduce more of a cinematic structure, we wanted them to have a beginning, middle and an end. We wanted a story structure but we also wanted to maintain an element of live improvisation too. Having been influenced by jazz music from a very young age, I felt it was a bit like that with our live cinema work. There's a structural element, which might often be the narrative, and then there's a percussive time signature for the music which gives the piece a structure. And then around these structural elements there are more improvised elements, elements that can move around, elements that change and are different each time.

I think one of the fundamental differences in live cinema performances are that the work can evolve in real-time, and upon reflection after each show. You can change it and add to it over time, it responds to the performer and reacts to its audiences. When you talk to people after the show, you get a sense of, did that work? Or did that not work? And you can change things around,

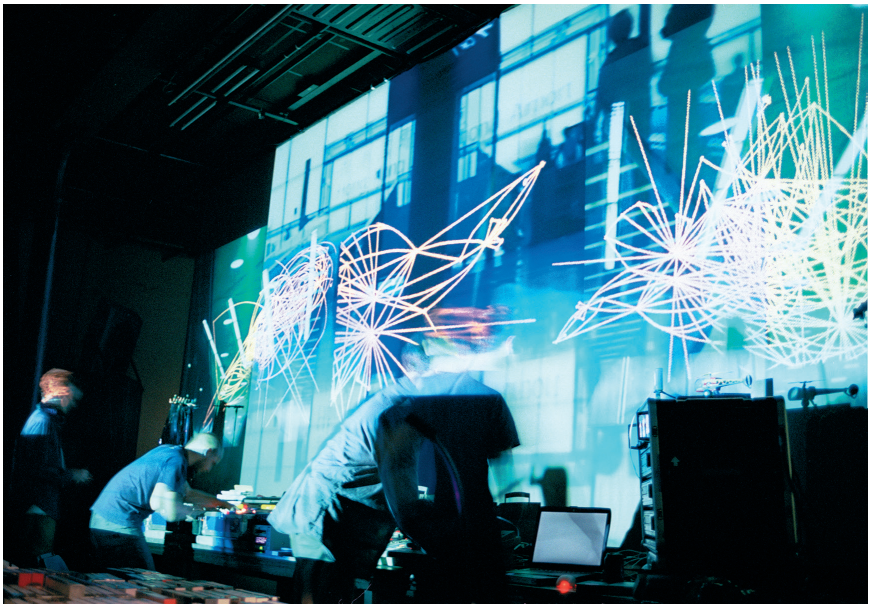

FIGURE 17.3 The Light Surgeons, *All Points Between*, World Wide Video Festival Amsterdam, 2001. Commissioned and developed by onedotzero festival. Photo by Matt Jinx. Used by Permission.

Source: Mail conversation with artist available on request.

so it's a much more a responsive form of film. It's an iterative process in a way, a bit like software in a sense. Cinema can mean so many different things to different people. Our work is quite structured around interviews and spoken word narratives which gives it a rooting in actuality and documentary. So that fixes it in time and gives it a story and structure which we then perform and improvise along to, trying to illustrate the story and the musical aspects through our different audio-visual material.

There are obviously lots of other things that live cinema can do that traditional cinema can't do. I would say that live cinema is somewhere between cinema and theatre as it happens in space in front of an audience. We love this spatial aspect in our work and our shows have always explored this. Most of our live cinema performances have been developed around this dual screen setup. This involves a theatrical gauze which covers the front of the stage and places us inside our material. We use multiple projections, multiple layers of images to play with multiple themes and layers of meaning, this creates a musicality to the pieces and allows us to improvise how these elements combine on stage and in space. The material can combine in unexpected ways, it can move around in that space. This use of multiple layers of screens allows us to actively play with our shadows and integrate the moments of the other live musicians. In this space we create something

that intersects between live music, cinema and performance art. It combines all of these things together. This collision of different sonic and visual elements creates these sublime moments, these happy accidents. I love the fact that you can have some structure, but then you can also kind of also just detour from that and just let things happen. And maybe because you have the structure there it has more meaning and significance, but it's very magical and what keeps me fascinated in it.

SG: The cinematic aspect of your work really strikes me as quite different than a lot of other people's Live Visual work. Let's give you an example: Carsten Nicolai, his work is quite abstract and geometrical. And it's very much driven by how the sound relates to it, which is true in your work too, but it seems to me that when you watch one of your longer projects, it does have, like you said, a sense of a beginning, middle, and end in a kind of a filmic sense.

CA: Maybe. I think part of what drove me to the work that we we've been making, and it's not just my work, there's a lot of people that have collaborated and worked together on these shows; is a bit of a frustration with abstraction. It too easy and I think I became a bit jaded by seeing it everywhere. Probably because I spent a lot of time doing work in lots of different event spaces and contexts, working with electronic music in particular for many years and often creating these static visual environments for people, it became a bit stale and meaningless for me. When I started making live cinema work, when it became an audio-visual thing, when it wasn't just us producing a visual illustration to someone else's music, we were actually creating the music, we were creating audio-visual work that was also exploring a narrative as well. I think it was a reaction to abstraction in a way. We wanted to bring a more human, storytelling element into this cultural space because it felt to me like it was too easy to just create abstract works. However, abstraction is a very commercially successful way to approach art, it always has been. It allows the audience to project their own meaning and that's very appealing to people. It's not that I don't enjoy this type of work, I think Carsten Nicolai's work is amazing and enjoy it very much. I think it's actually a very good reflection of that Raster-Noton[2] kind of sound. It's a very minimalist, and purist type of sound and it captures that electronic aesthetic perfectly.

SG: I probably shouldn't have used him as an example.

CA: I think he's a good example. I think there's lots of other artists' work you could look at too, you see it in painting as well. You can look back over the history of contemporary art and see that lots of artists have made this kind of abstract expressionism and have become very commercially successful because people can put it in their homes or in their offices without offending anyone. Audiences can project their own meaning and see themselves reflected back at them. Everyone loves that. It has an openness that maybe work that's more narrative or figurative doesn't, work that's more rooted in reality, or that could be seen as realist doesn't.

I became a lot more motivated by trying to explore how one might represent reality through this lens of live cinema, and particularly through this passion for research and interviewing people. I love going out into the world and gathering the material. I became interested in the history of this practice, in the ideas around psychogeography, the history of mass observation and the beginnings of documentary film, in filmmakers like Humphrey Jennings.[3] I love this idea of participating in the world and reflecting it back in the work. I felt some responsibility to do this, in having access to the technology, in having the luxury to own this ability, I really felt there was an obligation to attempt to tell stories that were relevant to people, that were asking questions and were reflecting what was happening socially and politically at the time we were living through.

That was my choice and the other people that I worked with shared that idea I think, so it's reflected in the work. There are also layers of abstraction in it too, particularly in graphic material which responds and reflects the music more perhaps. Our performance called *SuperEverything**, that has quite an interesting use of layering and there are parts of that show where we go off into abstraction, into glitchy weird stuff, but it's got a meaning and a reason to be there (see Figure 17.4). It's always rooted in extending the story

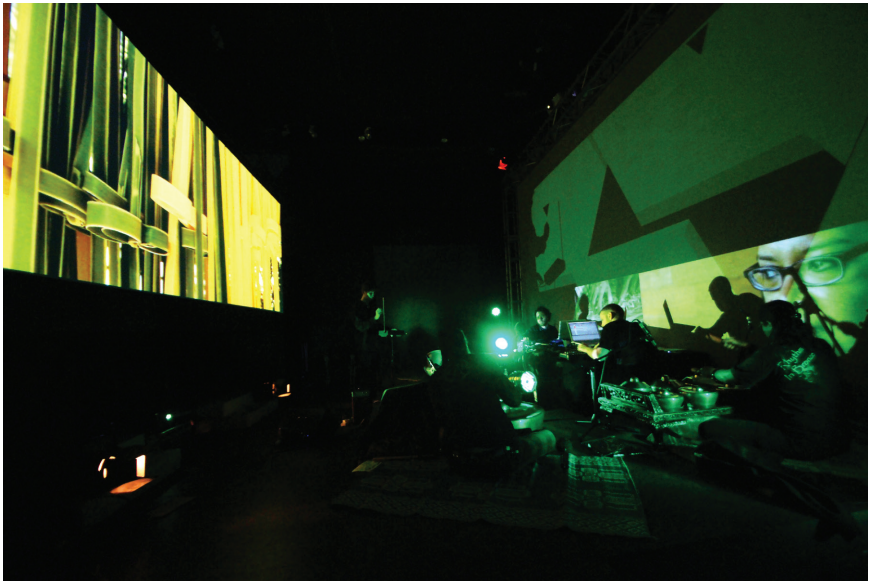

FIGURE 17.4 *SuperEverything** live cinema performance by The Light Surgeons at the Asia Society Theatre, Houston, Texas, 2012. *SuperEverything** supported by Arts Council England. ©2013 by The Light Surgeons. Used by Permission.

Source: Mail conversation with artist available on request.

that's being told by the people we have interviewed. I think there is a sort of Neo-realism within the work that I like, that I find interesting, I think if you if you are going to be an artist, it's important to you make work that you appreciate, and hope that other people will share that.

SG: Your work with The Light Surgeon spans quite a number of diverse productions, including live cinema, audio-visual performance, more commercially oriented work and public installation projects. So you're covering a lot of ground. Do you consciously use different methods and approaches in these different spheres? Or do you move technologies, forms and concepts between them?

CA: We've diversified from our roots from working pretty much in a live performance environment, and have moved into doing gallery-based installation work and exhibitions. I've always been a bit suspicious of the art world myself. I am someone who trained as a graphic designer so maybe this relates also to your previous question. I've always approached my work with a sense of design and problem solving. I always feel there's got to be a message, there has got to be something you're trying to express or say to the audience. I think people that come to this type of work, or this area, from a more fine art background, maybe they don't have that sensibility so much. I have this deep feeling that something has to have some tangible meaning or that there's got to be a use or utility to it. That it's not just navel gazing, that it's not just all about me or my personal angst. I mean, it's not I'm against personal angst, that has its place and can also be meaningful, but I think, for me, I've always tried to approached things in a more pluralistic way and to communicate a message to an audience and maybe that's because I come from a design background.

That sensibly has definitely led us as a studio and as a group of collaborating artists, designers and filmmakers. We've managed to balance doing design work and creating our own collective artworks. Sometimes the two things are very related and inform each other. I'll give you an example, the very first live cinema show we did was drawn from material from a design project that we'd been paid to create. Very often our artistic vocabulary was generated from the different experiments and creative ideas we had gathered through the creation of our more commercial design projects. Often it was after we delivered a project we were able to repurpose it and put it back together as something else, as an artwork. So there's always been this kind of relationship for us between the artwork and a design process.

I think we always bringing an element of design thinking to our projects subconsciously. Even when we're making our own artwork, we try to create a brief for ourselves and trying to think, what's the best way to express this? What kind of materials do we want to use? We'll never jump to a conclusion like this needs to be video mapping, or this needs to be done like this, or with this technique. It's the same when we work with a client, we are always asking, what are you trying to say? Who are you trying to talk to? What's the context? We go through a very methodical design process in order to choose

the right approach to the information, to choose the right approach to the technology, to choose the right materials. And all these things change with different situations – if we're working in a museum context, for instance, sometimes you're dealing with physical design decisions that aren't yours, that are out of your hands. Then sometimes you can be working in a situation where you can define your space, you can define the kind of physicality of the space and define the boundaries your working with more. There's been quite a few projects where we've ended up working with an exhibition designer who has already conceptualised and defined a lot of these things, and we're in a position where we have to retrofit our ideas in order to make sense of their design decisions, and it can be frustrating and a challenge, but it can also throw up some really interesting results because of this.

As a designer and an artist, I always try to see any problems as the solution. And I know that's a cliché, but I think it's proved really true in my experience, often its these barriers, these limitations or boundaries, these things you come up against where you're like, oh how's this gonna work? That you really have to fight against to find a way around. It's in these situations were creativity kicks in, ideas are created, where art is created, I think you can often find something special in those limitations. I think limitation definitely breeds creativity.

SG: There's a quote from Stravinsky, the composer. He said, when I sit down in front of the page, I think of what I shouldn't do.

CA: I've actually been stumped by offers to do projects where they've not really given me any limitations. I have found that quite difficult. I always feel there needs to be some sort of time or budgetary limitation in order for me to conceptualise it, I can be ridiculously ambitious with projects, probably to my detriment, so if someone says, "Oh, you can just do whatever you want." it freaks me out!

SG: Let's switch over to the music side of things. You've obviously worked with a really wide variety of musicians for your own projects, and for the projects with The Light Surgeons. Could you describe how you work with musicians in a live context and explain your process of collaboration, maybe focusing on one or two collaborations?

CA: Are you speaking more specifically with our live cinema work?

SG: It could be your live cinema work, or even the more commercial work you've done with some bands.

CA: We've done lots of projects that are audio-visual, from creating our own short films, which also have a large amount of sound design and music in them, to our installation projects. Sound is a really important aspect of our work. It's 50% of the project most of the time. People don't think of that because maybe they associate us with Live Visuals and our work for other artists, but a lot of our work involves the recording of sound and the composing of music alongside the creation of the visuals. We've actually published a double vinyl album of the music and documentary narratives in our *True Fictions* live cinema performance. It's a very important thing to

acknowledge. I've always been personally really influenced by sound and do like to play with making music, but I can't take much credit for that aspect of our work, the musical compositions and sound design have been mainly created by artists and composers such as Tim Cowie, Jude Greenaway and Malcolm Litson along with various collaborators in the US and Malaysia.

A good example of how we integrate the sound and musical production into a project would be something like our live cinema project *Super-Everything**. This was initiated through the music department at the British Council, so that the whole project came out of the desire to initiate a musical collaboration across cultures. After it was initially created, the project subsequently got UK funding from the Arts Council, also through music rather than visual arts. I think that's quite interesting, because people probably don't see us as composers. But that project, which I would say is one of the best projects we've ever made, came from a funding platform which supported music and the rest of the filmmaking kind of blossomed out of that initial invitation from the British Council to collaborate in Malaysia.

We were introduced to a range of different artists and musicians during a research trip in 2010. We chose four sound artists from Kuala Lumpur to work with. There were two major groups: one was a Chinese drumming group called Hands Percussion,[4] who were quite established and have several troupes and do these quiet theatrical performances with traditional drums. There was a group called Rhythm in Bronze[5] who are largely a female gamelan group. And there were also two other solo artists who contributed, an artist called Flica, who does post-rock electronica music, and then an artist called Chor Guan Ng, a Chinese-Malaysian composer who really contributed the most musically and ended up becoming very involved in the project, touring with it and performing live. He's a classically trained pianist who can play the Theremin like no one else I've ever heard. He also became very involved in the writing and composing of a string trio which we added to the show when we toured it in the UK. Tim Cowie, the other main composer and musical director of the project, worked together on developing that and it was really beautiful and is soon to get its own vinyl release on the record label Utter.

That project also had a very large and ambitious documentary film aspect to it, the project tells this story about identity, ritual and place through a series of audio-visual tracks that travel across the landscape of Malaysia, looking at everything from shopping, religion, and the environment and how these things effect people. We interviewed lots of different people from all the main ethnic and cultural backgrounds, including the indigenous Orang Asli people. As a result, it's got this very epic, pluralistic story of our collective humanity.

The music which came out of the project is a combination of Tim's interest in electronic synthesis, he's really into modular synths and electronic processes, but also contemporary classical compositions. It was

also shaped by an experimental approach to field recording during our production trips. We did a lot of recording with this thing called a loop inductor, which is often used in exhibitions for picking up transmitted sound for the deaf and hard of hearing, but you can also use them without any transmission to pick up interference from the environment. When we were filming we took it with us and we recorded different electrical interferences, this weird unheard soundscape that you can find listening with these things. We tend to use a lot of field recording in our projects. When we are filming we're always very conscious of capturing sound, we are always gathering different wild tracks and ambiences that we think will form interesting textures in a show.

SG: Did you work [in the field] with the four artists as well?

CA: Yes. Some of the sound artists came and worked with us when we were filming. Chor Guan Ng did some of the production when we went and filmed in shopping centres. He took a zoom out and he recorded stuff most days I think. For the major musical groups that we worked with, Hands Percussion and Rhythm in Bronze, because of the very limited amount of time we had with them, and because of their huge instruments, we only had a couple of days in a black box theatre space to record their contributions. We essentially did sessions where they performed different improvised arrangements that they wanted to contribute. These were also filmed because we knew we wanted to include their contributions in the visuals at some point, as we knew they might not be available to perform live everywhere that project might go. So there was a series of these experimental recording sessions where they played different arrangements, and we played arrangements back to them. We also showed them video footage we had gathered and they responded to it live. It was a really interesting and collaborative process. These recordings were then re-arranged and sampled to form the structure of the music in the show by Tim and Guan. We had the opportunity to invite them to tour with the project as live musicians later on which was amazing, we took them to perform at the shows we did in Australia and a big outdoor performance we did in LA in the United States.

With our live cinema work, what we attempt to do is to make both the music and the film aspects of the projects together. We don't make a film and then score it, we're making the music and the film at the same time. That's really reflected in the work I think, there's a symbiosis between sound and image, we strive to make things very audio-visual, and there's a lot of cross fertilisation that goes into making the work and then that all feeds into how it happens live as a performance.

Chor Guan Ng is probably the artist that's performed with us live on *SuperEverything** the most. He plays live piano and he does this really cool live Foley sound as well. His presence on stage also got us excited about creating interesting shadows and using directional lighting to blur the performance with the live video. We really wanted to play with this idea of a modern take on the ancient art of *Wayang Kulit*, the traditional shadow

puppet theatre from Malaysia. This is something I've been really influenced by, this idea of the origin of film and cinema, that cinema really originates from this very live theatrical medium that's thousands of years old, that goes back to the telling of the ancient myths of India, and these incredible stories of the *Bhagavad Gita*. I'd like to imagine there's some connection there with what we're trying to achieve with film and cinema today, using modern tools to tell contemporary stories about now with images, sounds and voices.

Guan's a very central character on stage during the performance, he's doing all sorts of mad stuff during the show like chopping up vegetables, we do a whole rhythmic thing with a knife and a chopping board and contact mics at one point. He also does other weird foley things throughout the show that are caught as shadows by the lighting in beautiful ways, like playing bowls of water as percussion by slapping the surface of the water with his hands and creating these ripples and refractions of light on the screen. The creation of sound becomes a very real visual element in the piece to the point that sometimes, we're thinking how can we create interesting shadows? So the audio and visual elements are really influencing one another all the way through from production to performance.

SG: But it's not like using digital signal processing, which a lot of people would use just to get that kind of rhythmic connection. It's much more tactile, if you like.

CA: There is digital signal processing, that's part of it, but we have both. There are layers of each going on at the same time. In a physical live sense, Guan is doing a lot of live, improvisation on stage, and myself and Tim are running all of this other stuff live, but electronically. We're using the Ableton Live software, and we're using the VDMX software live. We've got three computers that are chained together over a network, we're using MIDI over a LAN connection so that when we're triggering stuff it stays in time to a central MIDI clock. I'm also triggering video clips using an Akai drum machine that also has sound on it, and that audio is running through a Pioneer DJ mixer that has MIDI on it. If I add a filter from the Pioneer mixer, I can link that sound effect to a visual effect on the computer, like adding a blur or something in VDMX. In this way I'm able to link visual filters to audio filters at the same time. Then I'm free to express myself and improvise by building up and subtracting layers, adding textures and ambiences, punctuating and manipulating the sound and image together. That's where the live audio-visual thing happens for me during the show, and all these elements come together to form a whole.

SG: What do you consider to be the core conceptual, formal, artistic, technological, political, or any other values that inform your work?

CA: With the design work, I think it's responding to the brief, and it's really considering what the best response is to the context and the audience. I think for me, that's really central for any kind of project I create: what is being communicated and what is the message, who are you talking to and what the context is for this is central.

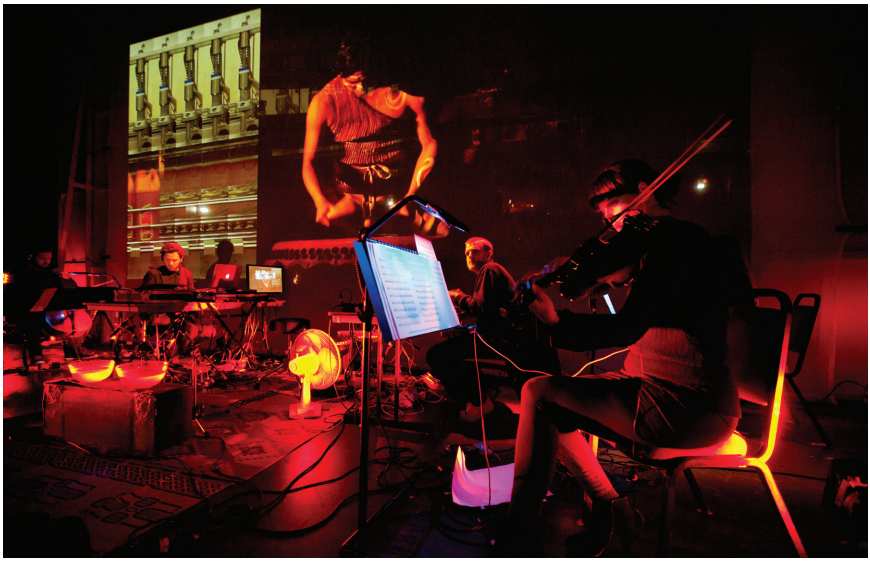

FIGURE 17.5 *SuperEverything** performance at Warwick Arts Centre," 2013/ Photo by Nik Eagland. *SuperEverything** supported by Arts Council England. ©2013 by The Light Surgeons. Used by permission.

Source: Mail conversation with artist available on request.

With our artwork, our films and our live cinema performances, I think we set out with a goal to transport people somewhere. Where they may be able to view the world slightly differently and form a new perspective (see Figure 17.5). I was very influenced by quite ambitious and lofty films like *Koyaanisqatsi*,[6] and films that provide a 'Mondo' view on the world. I love to contemplate the macro and micro, to see the whole and the details at the same time. I think this is an approach that has really influenced me and I've been trying to re-create that with my work: to elevate people to contemplate the world around them in a slightly different way to before that experienced the work hopefully. I hope the result is not just entertaining, but it asks make people think a little and contemplate too.

SG: There is a bit of an agenda, if not quite in a didactic way?

CA: I like to ponder things. I like to consider the world. I'm interested in the world around me, and I'm interested in people, and I'm interested in politics, and I'm interested in why we exist, I'm interested in theology, I'm interested in deep questions about who we are as human beings, and I like to provoke people to think that about these ideas too.

SG: So it comes back to the question about meaning?

CA: I think art has a very important a role to play in society, it's about reflecting on ourselves, about understanding who we are, about imagining where

we might want to be and where we might go in the future. I think art has got a central role to play and we are very fortunate to be able to create the work we make. Everything in this room has been imagined, every single object, everything that you see that is man-made, has been imagined, so that means it has come from someone's brain, it has been realised and turned into an artefact or object. That's quite a profound thing to consider I think, to take on board that responsibility of imagining, and that's why I think I want to try to make something positive, to provoke people. I think it would be a shame not to do that. I just like to see work that attempts reflect the wonder of the world, so I try to make work that provokes a sense of wonder. I think the more I do that in my daily life, the better my daily life is. The more time I spend not sweating the small stuff, the better I can cope with all the uncertainly and stress of life. The more I think about the world in a more abstract sense, like the fact we are all just very small organic things on a crust of a ball of fire that's floating through space, the more I'm able to think of myself within that broader idea of the universe. The more I can relate to this wider view for the world and my place in it, the less stressed I am and the more open I am. I don't think that these ideas and thoughts are necessarily didactic, there is just a passion for trying to engage people in a sense of wonder, to transport them somewhere with the work we make. If people are going to give you their attention for 45 minutes or an hour in a performance, it's nice to think, okay, they're going to come out of it with something, rather than make it an endurance for them.

Notes

1 Onedotzero Official Website, www.onedotzero.com/.
2 Raster official website, https://raster-media.net/.
3 David Parkinson, "Where to Begin with Humphrey Jennings," BFI Official website, www.bfi.org.uk/features/where-begin-humphrey-jennings.
4 Hands Percussion Official website, www.hands.com.my/.
5 Rhythm in Bronze Official website, www.rhythminbronze.com/.
6 Godfrey Reggio, *The Qatsi Trilogy*, Official Website, 1972–2021, www.koyaanisqatsi.org/.